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New Diplomacy with Pakistan

2004-2008

Easing cross-border movement of people, encouraging trade and cultural cooperation—tested components of India's diplomatic toolkit to reduce tensions with recalcitrant neighbours—were intensified with Pakistan in 2004-08. The real innovation was replicating these measures across the Line of Control dividing Jammu and Kashmir. Pakistan's domestic convulsions and terrorist attacks wrecked the process, but it remains a template to be factored into future initiatives.



AP

Neighbours at PM Modi's Swearing-In

2014

Optics are important in diplomacy and inviting SAARC heads of government to attend his swearing-in was an inspired move by PM designate **Narendra Modi**. Significantly, all the invitations were accepted, including by Pakistan, with the then premier Nawaz Sharif attending the ceremony. Things did not work out as anticipated, especially with Pakistan and Nepal, but the initiative itself remains a benchmark for neighbourhood relations as a demonstration of bold and imaginative political diplomacy.

OIC foreign ministers' meet

Abu Dhabi, 2019

That external affairs minister Sushma Swaraj would be invited to address the OIC foreign ministers as a guest of honour in Abu Dhabi in March 2019 astounded many, given India's friction-ridden interface with the organisation since its establishment. The event remains a testimony to the virtues of quiet and patient diplomacy and equally of how PM Modi's efforts to nurture bilateral ties with each of the Gulf states paid off in a multilateral success that remains a template for future action.

